in non-traditional areas like Bengal and Odisha. *'Odisha aur Bengal mein to chamatkar ho sakta hai'* (There could be a miracle in Odisha and Bengal), Modi told me once, excitedly. He even ventured into small states like Arunachal and Manipur. 'Every seat counts,' was his mantra.

I asked Modi in one phone conversation what kept him going. *'Yeh toh ab ek mission hai, ek junoon hai. Mehnat karne se aadmi kabhi nahi thakta!'* (This is now a mission, a craze. No one gets tired from doing hard work). I sensed that the early years of discipline in the shakha as an RSS pracharak were now an asset for life.

Much has been said about Modi's oratorical flourish. A close aide told me that their leader had a knack of being able to deliver a speech with minimal preparation. 'All we did was provide him a few bullet points detailing some local issues—the rest was all his mind.' One of his great skills was to convert an abstract idea into popular idiom. So, when some of his strategists in the last phase of the campaign suggested that the BJP should push for a stable government, Modi went to Himachal and delivered a simple slogan, *'Yeh Dil Maange More!'*, referring to the famous words of Param Vir Chakra winner and Kargil hero, Captain Vikram Batra. When the Congress challenged his 'idea of India', Modi countered by unveiling his *indradhanush* (rainbow) of ideas by quoting from the Upanishads and the Rig Veda.

Vajpayee had been the BJP's supreme political orator. I remember Advani once almost enviously confessing, 'We used to be awestruck just listening to Atalji speak.' Vajpayee's style was that of the poet-politician—lyrical and emotional, he could sway an audience with the *jadoo* (magic) of the Hindi language. Even his long pauses were redolent with meaning. He could leave you teary-eyed as he did me when I heard him speak during the 1999 Lahore bus yatra. Modi is different. His style is that of the pugnacious streetfighter, full of machismo. He can captivate you with his energetic presence and rapid-fire one-liners, but he doesn't tug at your heart.

Modi's speeches at the rallies had a set pattern. He would begin by applauding the audience while slowly raising the pitch. A few words in the local language would enthuse the crowds. While raising a local issue, he